



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MSN 1837 (M) Amendment 3: Categorisation of Waters

Updated 30 May 2024

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Summary

This statutory Merchant Shipping Notice sets out the categorisations of waters in the United Kingdom.

Key Points

- The categorisations determine the waters not regarded as “sea” for the purposes of Merchant Shipping legislation (excepting marine pollution).
- The notice replaces and augments MSN 1837 (M) Amendment 2 with new amendments in relation to waters in the vicinity of Barrow-in-Furness and Conwy.

1. Introduction

1.1 The Annex to this Merchant Shipping Notice sets out the categorisations that apply to waters in the United Kingdom. These categorisations are given statutory force by way of Regulation 3(2)(a) of the Merchant Shipping (Categorisation of Waters) Regulations 1992.

2. Definitions of categorised waters

2.1 Category A: Narrow Rivers and canals where the depth of water is generally less than 1.5 metres.

2.2 Category B: Wider rivers and canals where the depth of water is generally 1.5 metres or more and where the significant wave height could not be expected to exceed 0.6 metres at any time.

2.3 Category C: Tidal rivers and estuaries and large, deep lakes and lochs where the significant wave height could not be expected to exceed 1.2 metres at any time.

2.4 Category D: Tidal rivers and estuaries where the significant wave height could not be expected to exceed 2.0 metres at any time.

3. Application

3.1 These categorisations apply specifically to any vessel certified to operate in waters which are not regarded as “sea” for the purposes of regulations made, or treated as made, under Section 85 of the Merchant Shipping Act.

3.2 Under the Merchant Shipping (Prevention of Oil Pollution) Regulations 2019 it should be noted that “sea” includes any estuaries or arms of the sea.

3.3 These categorisations should not be confused with sea areas for Passenger Ships as designated in the Merchant Shipping (Passenger Ships on Domestic Voyages) Regulations 2000.

3.4 The categorisations shown in the Annex apply at all times of the year unless otherwise indicated. “Summer” means the months of April to October, inclusive, and “winter” means the months of November to March, inclusive.

More information

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